

STARTER

Field-by-Field Online Application Walkthrough

Canada - Study Permit

VERIFY BEFORE YOU APPLY

Fees, forms, and processing times change without notice. This guide reflects publicly documented procedures as commonly published; treat every dollar figure, form number, and timeline here as a starting point, and confirm the current version on the official government site before you submit anything or pay any fee.

Before you start

A Study Permit is applied for online through your IRCC secure account (the paper form, for the small number of applicants who must apply on paper, is IMM 1294). It's decided by an IRCC visa officer under the Immigration and Refugee Protection Act (IRPA) and Regulations (IRPR). Gather the following before you begin:

- Your Letter of Acceptance from a Designated Learning Institution (DLI) - a Canadian school, college, or university on IRCC's list of approved institutions, each with its own DLI number
- A Provincial or Territorial Attestation Letter (PAL), if your situation requires one - introduced as part of Canada's international student cap; some categories of applicant are exempt, so check current exemptions on IRCC's website
- Valid passport or other travel document
- Financial evidence meeting the published cost-of-living formula - see the Financial Requirements Overview (Essential tier)
- A study plan explaining why you chose this program and institution, and your plans afterward
- Academic transcripts and any language test results your Letter of Acceptance was conditional on

YOUR DLI NUMBER MATTERS

Every field on your application relating to your school must exactly match your Letter of Acceptance - the institution's legal name, its DLI number, your program, and your start date. A mismatch between your Letter of Acceptance and your application is one of the most common, entirely avoidable causes of delay or refusal; see the Refusal Reasons guide.

Section-by-section

1. Personal details

Name, date of birth, nationality, and passport details exactly as they appear in your passport - and exactly as they were given to your DLI when your Letter of Acceptance was issued.

2. Your DLI and program details

- Enter your DLI number and program details exactly as shown on your Letter of Acceptance
- If you're under the age (commonly 17 or 18, depending on the province) where a custodian is required, you'll need a custodianship declaration - check your destination province's specific age threshold

3. Financial information

You'll declare how you're funding your tuition and living costs, and provide supporting evidence against the published formula - see the Financial Requirements Overview and the Financial Planning Calculator (Premium tier).

4. Study plan

A short written explanation of why you chose this program and institution, how it fits your academic or career background, and your plans after you complete it. This is where the officer assesses whether your intentions are genuine - see the Study Plan Templates (Complete tier).

5. Background and travel history

Previous visas, visits, refusals (from Canada or any other country), and any immigration violations - answer completely.

6. Admissibility declarations

Standard declarations covering criminal convictions, medical conditions relevant to admissibility, and security concerns. Answer honestly.

7. Pay the fee and give biometrics

After submitting, you pay the processing fee (and a separate biometric fee, unless exempt). You'll then be instructed to visit a Visa Application Centre (VAC) for fingerprints and a photo, unless exempt.

8. Upload supporting documents

Upload your Letter of Acceptance, PAL (if required), financial evidence, and study plan. IRCC may send a procedural fairness letter requesting clarification - respond by the stated deadline if this happens.